

The Entrepreneur's PR Interview Guide: Mastering Your Media Moment

An EWOR Checklist

Getting media coverage is a huge win for any startup. A successful interview can boost visibility, credibility, and customer interest. But a poorly handled one can do the opposite. Preparation is everything.

This cheat sheet provides the golden rules and steps to ensure you ace your next interview.

Step 1

Preparation: Know Before You Go

This is the most critical phase. Never walk into an interview unprepared.

1 Know the Journalist

Action: Read their recent articles (especially on topics related to your industry). Check their LinkedIn and Twitter profiles. Understand their beat, style, and common angles.

Why: Builds rapport ("I enjoyed your piece on X"), helps you anticipate their perspective, and tailor your language. Are they known for technical deep dives or broader business stories?

2 Know the Publication & Its Audience

Action: Understand who reads/watches/listens to this outlet. Is it industry insiders, potential customers, investors, the general public? What's the publication's general tone (e.g., pro-business, tech-focused, critical)?

Why: Helps you frame your messages in a way that resonates with the audience, not just the journalist. Use language and examples they will understand.

3 Know the Reporter's Experience & Angle

Action: Gauge their familiarity with your specific market or technology. Did the person booking the interview give you insight into the intended angle of the story?

Why: Helps you know whether to start with basics or dive deeper. Understanding the likely angle helps you prepare relevant points.

4 Know the Story Type (Framing/Context — "Einordnung")

Action: Understand the bigger picture ("umbrella") the journalist is likely painting. Is this a trend piece, a company profile, a reaction to news, a competitive landscape overview? Crucially: In which bucket do you want your company to be sorted? How do you want to be framed within that context?

Why: Allows you to proactively position yourself within the narrative, rather than just reacting. If it's a story on "Challenges in AI," frame how you overcome them. If it's about "Innovations in Fintech," frame how you're leading.

5 Anticipate the Questions

Action: Brainstorm potential questions – the easy ones, the tough ones, the specific ones related to the story angle. Think: What might they have researched about you and the company? (Check old blog posts, press releases, social media messages, funding announcements, competitor news).

Why: Reduces surprises and allows you to practice your answers, especially for tricky topics (e.g., competition, past pivots, sensitive data).

6 Know Your Competitors' Messaging & Positioning

Action: Briefly review how your main competitors position themselves in the media. What are their key messages?

Why: Helps you differentiate yourself clearly and concisely. You can preemptively address competitive claims or highlight your unique value proposition.

7 Define Your Core Message

→ **The MOST Important Step**

Action: Determine the 2–3 **key messages** you absolutely must convey, regardless of the questions asked. These should be clear, concise, memorable, and relevant to the interview's purpose. Write them down! **Focus on 2–3!**

Why: Ensures you achieve your communication goal for the interview. It's your North Star. Everything else should support these messages.

Step 2

Execution: During the Interview

1 The Golden Rules of Interview Conduct

Be Authentic & Enthusiastic: Let your passion for your business shine through. Be yourself.

Be Clear & Concise: Avoid jargon unless the audience understands it. Get to the point. Short, impactful sentences are best.

Listen Carefully: Understand the entire question before answering.

It's Okay to Pause: Take a second to gather your thoughts before answering complex questions. Silence is better than rambling or misspeaking.

Stay Positive (Generally): Frame challenges as opportunities or learning experiences where appropriate. Avoid excessive negativity or blaming.

Nothing is "Off the Record" unless explicitly agreed beforehand: Assume everything you say can be printed. Be mindful of casual chat before or after the formal interview.

Don't Speculate Wildly: Stick to what you know. It's okay to say "I don't have the exact data on that, but what I can tell you is..." or "That's an interesting area for the future, but our current focus is on..."

Correct Politely if Misquoted/Misunderstood: "Just to clarify that point..."

Have Data/Proof Points Ready: Back up your claims with evidence (stats, customer examples, milestones).

2 Master the ABC Tactic:

A) Acknowledge: Briefly acknowledge the journalist's question. This shows you're listening and validates their inquiry. ("That's a great question," "I understand why you're asking that," "Yes, that's a challenge many in the industry face...").

B) Bridge: Smoothly transition from the question (even a difficult one) to one of your **Key Messages**. Use bridging phrases like:

- "What's most important to remember is..."
- "That ties into the core issue, which is..."
- "And that's exactly why we developed..."
- "While that's one aspect, our main focus is on..."
- "What our customers tell us is crucial is..."

C) Conclude: Deliver your key message clearly and, ideally, back it up with a Proof Point (a stat, a short anecdote, a customer result, a milestone).

3 Remember: What is said at the end stays in your head

("Was am Ende gesagt wird bleibt im Kopf"):

Action: Try to end the interview by briefly reiterating your most important message or a positive forward-looking statement. If the journalist asks "Anything else you'd like to add?", use this opportunity strategically!

Why: Leaves a strong final impression and reinforces your core takeaway.

Step 3

Post-Interview Follow-Up

1

Thank You

Send a brief email thanking the journalist for their time.

2

Offer Help

Offer to provide clarification or additional information if needed.

3

Share (If Appropriate):

When the article is published, share it on your company's social media channels (and tag the journalist/publication if appropriate).

How to

How to Tailor This To Your Situation / Company / Reason to Communicate:

The core principles remain the same, but what you emphasize changes based on the **reason for the interview**:

Product Launch:

Key Messages Focus

Problem solved, unique features / benefits, target customer, call to action (e.g., where to learn more/buy).

Tailoring

Prepare demos/visuals if possible. Anticipate questions about differentiation, pricing, availability.

Thought Leadership/Trend Piece:

Key Messages Focus

Unique perspective on the industry, insights, predictions, how your company fits into/shapes the trend.

Tailoring

Prepare broader industry points, not just company specifics. Show you understand the bigger picture.

Company Milestone: (e.g., Anniversary, Expansion).

Key Messages Focus

Journey/growth story, impact achieved, future plans, thanking stakeholders (team, customers).

Tailoring

Prepare key achievements and future outlook points.

Funding Announcement:

Key Messages Focus

Vision, market opportunity, validation (why these investors?), use of funds, team strength.

Tailoring

Be ready to discuss market size, growth plans, investor confidence. Avoid over-promising specific financial projections unless required and cleared.

Crisis Communication:

Note: Requires very careful preparation, often with PR professional help.

Key Messages Focus

Acknowledgment of the issue (with empathy if needed), facts, actions being taken, commitment to resolution/prevention.

Tailoring

Stick rigidly to approved messaging. Anticipate difficult questions. Focus on transparency and action.

Examples

Scenario

- You are the founder of "EcoPack," a Berlin-based startup making compostable packaging from agricultural waste.
- You have an interview about entering the French market.

1

Preparation

Journalist

Reporter for "Sustainable Business Europe," covers circular economy innovations. Often asks about regulatory hurdles and environmental certifications.

Publication/Audience

European business leaders, sustainability professionals, policymakers.

Story Type

Company expansion / International business. Bucket: "Scaling Circular Economy Solutions."

Angle

German startup expanding sustainable solutions internationally.

Competitors

Existing French bio-plastic firms, traditional packaging. Messaging focuses on local sourcing or established relationships.

Anticipated Qs

Why France? French regulations? Production capacity? Cost comparison? Certifications obtained? (Might check LinkedIn for team members with French experience).

Key Messages

01

EcoPack provides a certified compostable packaging solution that helps businesses meet EU sustainability targets.

02

Our expansion into France addresses strong market demand for eco-friendly alternatives and leverages local agricultural byproducts.

03

This move demonstrates the scalability and international viability of our waste-to-value model.

2

Execution (ABC Example)

Journalist Question

"Entering France means dealing with a different regulatory environment and established local players. How significant are those challenges?"

Your answer

(A) Acknowledge

"That's a very relevant point. Navigating new markets always involves understanding the local landscape, including regulations."

(B) Bridge

"However, what's driving our confidence is the alignment between French environmental goals and our core offering. In fact, the demand for certified compostable solutions is rapidly increasing there..."

(C) Conclude

(Key Message 1 & 2 + Proof)

"...which is why EcoPack is so well-suited. Our packaging is already certified [mention relevant EU/French certification], directly helping businesses meet those targets, and we've secured initial partnerships with French distributors specifically because of this alignment and our ability to utilize local agricultural waste streams."



Final Thought

Preparation transforms an interview from a potentially stressful interrogation into a valuable opportunity to tell your story effectively.

Remember that last impression – make it count! Good luck!